Approval Note: Version 1.0

Dear Leadership team,

I am seeking an approval for a ₹32 crore promotional investment to be executed in Q3 FY26. This is to arrest the ongoing decline in volumes (down by 7.2% YoY) and market share observed over the last two quarters. In this period the industry grew 4.8% and our top three competitors increased promotional spends by 25–30%, resulting in a material loss of visibility and trial for our core portfolio.

We will manage the financial risks by phased execution, budget caps and a buffer for competitive scenarios. All functions have concurred except Procurement and Legal. Would need your help in aligning them too.

Background (Last 6 Months vs Last Year)
Industry:

- FMCG category value growth: +4.8% YoY (Nielsen, rolling 6 months)
- Promotional intensity (price-offs + bundles): +22% YoY
- Modern trade share of promotions increased from 38% to 44%

Competition:

- Competitor A: Avg. consumer discount 16–18%, sustained for 10–12 weeks
- Competitor B: Entry price packs down ₹10/unit, supported by heavy digital spends
- Combined competitor share gain: +280 bps

Our Performance:

- Q4 FY25 sales: ₹1,420 Cr → Q1 FY26 sales: ₹1,318 Cr
- Volume decline: –6.1% over two quarters
- Market share: 18.9% → 16.6% (–230 bps)
- Brand consideration: –8 points (tracking, June)
- Promotional spend as % of sales: 6.2% vs competition at 9.1%

Problem Statement
While base pricing and margins remain structurally sound, insufficient promotional presence over the last six months has led to reduced shelf visibility, lower trials and accelerated switching to competitors. Without corrective intervention in Q3, current forecasts indicate an additional 5–6% volume decline, putting full-year recovery at high risk.

The Solution (Key Benefits of the Promotion)
The proposed Q3 promotion aims to restore competitiveness at the shelf and online by offering a 12–15% effective consumer benefit through value packs and limited-period offers.

Expected Outcomes:

- Volume uplift of 10–12% during campaign window
- Incremental gross sales of ₹190–₹210 Cr
- Market share recovery of 140–160 bps

- Net incremental contribution of ₹38–₹45 Cr post-promotion
- Stabilization of brand consideration and improvement in trial-to-repeat conversion

Key Execution Next Steps

1. Regional / Geographic Budgeting
    - ₹32 Cr split: North (28%), West (26%), South (24%), East (22%)
    - Focus on top 60 cities contributing 72% of current decline
2. Supply Chain & Inventory Readiness
    - Build inventory to 1.4x projected uplift
    - Warehousing and secondary freight capacity locked for 8-week window
3. Sourcing & Manufacturing
    - Two plants aligned; third plant capacity confirmation pending
    - Incremental production run of 4.2 million units planned
4. Sales Force Enablement & Training
    - 2-week rapid training module for 1,200 frontline sales staff
    - Clear incentive linkage to promo execution and visibility compliance
5. Media & In-store Activation
    - ₹7 Cr digital spend; projected reach 45 million consumers
    - In-store visibility rollout across 18,000 modern trade outlets

Risks and Mitigations

- Margin erosion: Capped funding and SKU-level ROI thresholds
- Forward buying / stockpiling: Staggered regional rollout and sell-out tracking
- Supply disruption: Safety stock and dual sourcing for key inputs
- Competitive retaliation: ₹3 Cr contingency within approved budget
- Execution slippage: Weekly cross-functional war-room reviews

Cross-Functional Alignment Status

Aligned**:**

- Sales (channel strategy and execution readiness)
- Marketing (offer design, media, and communication)
- Finance (budget envelope and ROI framework)
- Supply Chain (final capacity confirmation for Plant 3)

Pending Alignment:

- Procurement (raw material pricing lock beyond 60 days)
- Legal (final approval of offer mechanics and T&Cs)

I request approval to release the ₹32 Cr budget by 12 July, enabling retailer negotiations and production planning to proceed without delay. Any postponement beyond this date materially reduces Q3 impact and limits recovery options for H2.

I am available to discuss assumptions, sensitivities, or alternatives in more detail.
Regards,
Sonalika Tensionwala

Approval Note: Version 2.0

Dear Leadership Team,

Over the last two quarters, competitors have increased their promotional spends by approximately 25–30%, while industry growth has been around 4.8%. Our brand consideration declined by 8 points, and promotional spend as a percentage of sales is currently 6.2%. Market share has also moved from 18.9% to 16.6%, and Q1 FY26 sales were ₹1,318 Cr compared to ₹1,420 Cr in Q4 FY25. We are proposing a ₹32 Cr promotional plan for Q3, with expected volume uplift of 10–12%, although Plant 3 capacity confirmation is still pending and procurement pricing is locked only for 60 days.

The FMCG category has grown by 4.8% over the last six months, and modern trade promotional intensity has increased from 38% to 44%. Competitor A has been running 16–18% discounts for up to 12 weeks, while Competitor B has reduced entry price points by ₹10 per unit. Our own market share declined by 230 bps, and volumes are down 6.1%. Digital spends across the category have also increased significantly.

Margins remain structurally sound, but promotional visibility has reduced. There is a risk of further volume decline of 5–6% based on forecasts. Trial has been impacted, and shelf presence has weakened, particularly in top cities.

The promotion will involve value packs with an effective consumer benefit of 12–15%. Incremental sales of ₹190–₹210 Cr are expected, with a net contribution of ₹38–₹45 Cr. Market share recovery of 140–160 bps is anticipated. Brand consideration is also expected to stabilize.

The ₹32 Cr budget will be split regionally, with North receiving 28% and East 22%. Incremental production of 4.2 million units is planned, subject to capacity confirmation. Sales force training will be rolled out to 1,200 staff over two weeks. Warehousing capacity has been tentatively blocked, and digital media of ₹7 Cr will be deployed

There is a risk of margin erosion, which will be capped. Forward buying may occur, so staggered rollouts will be used. Competitive retaliation is possible, and a ₹3 Cr contingency is included. Weekly reviews will be conducted.

Sales, Marketing, and Finance are aligned. Supply Chain, Procurement, and Legal alignment is pending.

Regards,
Pappu Prasad Pressure Kumar

Opening Paragraph exercise for Approval Note

Write an opening paragraph for the email below

Background:

Industry & Peer Landscape

- Over the last two years, 87% of comparable GCCs in India have adopted hybrid or full work-from-home models (NASSCOM, 2024).
- 62% of peer GCCs now offer 4–5 days of WFH as a standard policy for internal-facing roles.
- No major GCC in our industry segment currently mandates 100% work-from-office for all roles.

Competitive Positioning

- Competitor attrition (industry median): 14–16%
- Our attrition (FY24): 26.8% (up from 18.9% in FY22)
- Exit interview data shows 41% of leavers cite “lack of flexibility” as a primary reason.

Our Organizational Context

- Total headcount: ~10,000 employees
    - Bangalore: 6,200
    - Gurgaon: 3,800

- Internal satisfaction score (ESAT):
    - FY22: 72
    - FY23: 61

    - FY24: 54 (lowest recorded)
- Average commute time (recent survey of 7,400 employees):
    - 75 minutes one way
    - 2.5 hours per day / ~12.5 hours per week
- Reported extreme commute incidents (>4 hours):
    - 18–22 days per year, concentrated around festivals and monsoons

Problem Statement

Our continued mandatory work-from-office policy has become a structural disadvantage in talent retention, employee morale, and employer credibility. For a GCC that is internally facing, serving US and European stakeholders across time zones, physical presence has limited operational necessity but significant human cost. If unaddressed, current attrition and engagement trends will continue to erode institutional knowledge, delivery stability, and leadership trust.

The Solution

We propose a 5-day work-from-home mandate for all eligible roles in Bangalore and Gurgaon, effective for a 12-month pilot period.

Expected Benefits:

- Attrition reduction of 6–8 percentage points within 12 months
- Replacement cost avoidance of ₹85–₹95 Cr annually (based on avg. ₹4.2 lakh per exit)
- Productivity recovery of 8–10% through reduced fatigue and commute time
- ESAT improvement from 54 → 65+ within two survey cycles
- Stronger employer brand parity with industry peers

Beyond metrics, this policy addresses a growing sense among employees that their lived realities—traffic, safety, exhaustion—are being discounted. Correcting this is as much about leadership credibility as it is about efficiency.

Key Execution Next Steps

1. Policy Design & Eligibility Framework
    - Define eligible roles (expected coverage: ~92% of headcount)
    - Codify expectations on availability, outcomes, and time-zone overlap
2. Technology & Security Enablement
    - VPN scaling for 10,000 concurrent users
    - Endpoint security upgrades for ~3,000 additional home setups
3. Manager & Team Enablement
    - Mandatory training for 850 people managers on remote leadership
    - Clear performance measurement guidelines based on output, not presence
4. Facilities & Cost Rebalancing
    - Reduce office utilization by 55–60%
    - Potential annual savings of ₹22–₹28 Cr in facilities and operations

5. Pilot Review & Governance
    - Quarterly review on attrition, ESAT, productivity, and risk incidents

Risks and Mitigations

- Perceived drop in productivity: Output-based KPIs and monthly dashboards
- Manager capability gaps: Mandatory training and HR-led coaching
- Data security concerns: Enhanced device controls and audits
- Cultural dilution: Structured virtual rituals and quarterly in-person team days
- Stakeholder skepticism (US/EU): Clear SLAs and delivery metrics communicated upfront

Cross-Functional Alignment Status

Aligned:

- HR (policy framework, change management)
- IT Security (in-principle approval for scale-up)
- Finance (cost–benefit model)

Pending Alignment:

- Legal (policy wording and compliance)
- Facilities (lease rationalization approach)
- Corporate Communications (internal and leadership messaging)

I request approval to proceed with this policy change effective 1 October, subject to final alignments. This decision is not about convenience—it is about acknowledging reality, honoring our duty of care, and choosing to lead with both evidence and empathy.

Regards,
Neha Network Nigam

Opening Paragraph exercise for Analysis Note

Write an opening paragraph for the email below. Your opening paragraph should incorporate the following:

- **Clarity:** Is the problem framed crisply?
- **Ethos:** What makes you sound in control and credible?
- **Pathos:** Is customer impact acknowledged without panic?
- **Coherence:** Does the paragraph prepare the reader for the RCA?
- **Tone:** Calm urgency, not apology or blame

Dear Leadership Team,

Summary of the Issue

- Customer reviews citing “product unavailable” increased from **6% to 18%** over the last 6 weeks
- Online “out-of-stock” flags increased by **2.3x** across top 40 SKUs
- Store-level availability dropped below **92%** threshold in **14 of 28 regions**

Demand-Side Analysis

- Demand spike of **+17% vs forecast** driven by:
    - Regional promotions (North & West)
    - E-commerce algorithm-led visibility boosts
- Forecast accuracy declined from **89% to 74%** at SKU–city level
- New SKU introductions contributed to **12% forecast bias**

Manufacturing & Capacity Analysis

- Planned utilization: **85%** | Actual: **92%** (last 4 weeks)
- One critical line operated at **98% capacity**, reducing flexibility
- Changeover delays added **+36 hours** cumulative downtime
- No material raw-material shortages identified

Regional vs National Supply Issues

- **68%** of stock-outs are region-specific, not national
- South and East maintained **>95% availability**
- North Metro clusters accounted for **41%** of total complaints
- Inter-region stock transfer lead time averaged **9.5 days vs SLA of 5**

Allocation & Planning Gaps

- Central allocation followed national demand averages, missing regional spikes
- E-commerce channel received **+18% excess allocation** vs sell-through
- Modern trade shorted by **12%** during peak weeks
- Replenishment triggers fired weekly instead of daily in 7 regions

Key Root Causes Identified

- Demand signals not translated quickly enough into regional plans
- Manufacturing rigidity at peak utilization
- Allocation rules lagging channel velocity
- Delayed exception handling at regional DC level

Immediate Corrective Actions & Next Steps

- Daily demand sensing implemented for top 50 SKUs
- Regional allocation overrides activated (effective this week)
- Manufacturing changeover sequencing revised
- Inter-region transfer SLA reduced to **4 days**
- War-room governance with twice-weekly reviews until stability is restored

Regards
Bhola Nath Accidentally-Brilliant